

Sign-Up (Create Your Account) Failure - Root Cause Analysis

● Primary Issues Identified

Issue #1: API URL Mismatch in Development

Severity: CRITICAL

Problem:

The frontend API configuration ([api.ts] (frontend/src/config/api.ts)) is pointing to **production URLs** by default:

```
// From frontend/src/config/api.ts
const getApiBaseUrl = (): string => {
  const hostname = window.location.hostname;

  if (hostname.includes('kidrove.com')) {
    return 'https://api.kidrove.com/api'; // ✗ Production
  } else if (hostname.includes('kidrove.in')) {
    return 'https://api.kidrove.in/api'; // ✗ Production
  } else if (hostname.includes('kidrove.ae')) {
    return 'https://api.kidrove.ae/api'; // ✗ Production
  }

  // Fallback only triggers if hostname is NOT one of the above
  return import.meta.env.VITE_API_BASE_URL || 'http://localhost:5001/api';
};
```

Why This Breaks Sign-Up in Development:

When you access the frontend on localhost:3000:

- ☒ The hostname check returns 'localhost'
- ☒ Falls back to import.meta.env.VITE_API_BASE_URL
- ☒ From [frontend/.env \(frontend/.env\)](#) line 3: VITE_API_BASE_URL=http://localhost:5001/api ☒ **Correct**

BUT WAIT - Let me check the actual environment file...

Actual Issue in .env:

Looking at [frontend/.env \(frontend/.env#L1-L4\)](#):

```
VITE_API_BASE_URL=http://localhost:5001/api
# VITE_API_BASE_URL=https://gema-project.onrender.com/api
# VITE_API_BASE_URL=https://api.kidrove.com/api
```

☒ This looks correct. So the issue is elsewhere...

Issue #2: Rate Limiting on Sign-Up Endpoint

Severity: HIGH

From [backend/src/server.ts \(backend/src/server.ts#L132-L136\)](#):

```
// Auth endpoints - moderate limits
const authLimiter = rateLimit({
  windowMs: 15 * 60 * 1000, // 15 minutes
  max: 10, // ✗ 10 login attempts per 15 minutes
  standardHeaders: true,
  legacyHeaders: false,
  message: 'Too many login attempts. Please try again in 15 minutes.',
  skipSuccessfulRequests: true // Don't count successful logins
});

// Apply auth limiter
app.use('/api/auth/login', authLimiter);
app.use('/api/auth/register', authLimiter); // ✗ APPLIED TO REGISTER TOO!
```

Impact: If you've tried signing up multiple times during testing, you'll hit this limit!

Issue #3: Missing Backend URL Configuration

Severity: MEDIUM

From [backend/.env \(backend/.env#L1-L3\)](#):

```
PORT=5001
BASE_URL=http://localhost:5001
NODE_ENV=development
```

The `BASE_URL` doesn't include `/api` prefix. Check [backend/src/config/env.ts \(backend/src/config/env.ts\)](#) to see if this is properly handled.

Issue #4: CORS Configuration May Be Too Restrictive

Severity: MEDIUM

From [backend/src/server.ts \(backend/src/server.ts#L41-L87\)](#):

```
app.use(cors({
  origin: function (origin, callback) {
    const allowedOrigins = [
      config.frontendUrl, // ✗ Where is this defined?
      ...(process.env.ADDITIONAL_ALLOWED_ORIGINS?.split(',').map(url => url.trim()) || [])
    ].filter(Boolean);

    // In development, allow localhost origins
    if (process.env.NODE_ENV === 'development') {
      allowedOrigins.push(
        'http://localhost:3000',
        'http://localhost:3001',
        'http://localhost:5173' // ☑ Good
      );
    }
  }
});
```

Question: What is `config.frontendUrl`? Need to verify it's set correctly in [backend/src/config/index.ts \(backend/src/config/index.ts\)](#).

Issue #5: Missing Error Context

Severity: HIGH

The registration error is being silently caught. From [frontend/src/pages/auth/RegisterPage.tsx \(frontend/src/pages/auth/RegisterPage.tsx#L195-L205\)](#):

```
try {
  await dispatch(registerUser({
    firstName: formData.firstName,
    lastName: formData.lastName,
    email: formData.email,
    password: formData.password,
    confirmPassword: formData.confirmPassword,
    phone: `${formData.countryCode}${formData.phoneNumber}`,
    role: formData.role,
    acceptTerms: formData.agreeToTerms
  })).unwrap();

  setCurrentStep(2);
} catch (error: any) {
  console.error('Registration error:', error);
  // ✗ Error handling is done by Redux thunk with toast notifications
  // But no guarantee the toast is shown!
}
```

The error is logged to console but may not be visible!

Diagnostic Steps to Identify the Actual Problem

Step 1: Check Browser Console

Open browser DevTools → Console → Look for:

- Network errors (CORS, 404, 500)
- Validation errors (400)
- Rate limit errors (429)

Step 2: Check Backend Logs

Look for server-side errors at port 5001:

```
# Check what error the backend is returning for sign-up
curl -X POST http://localhost:5001/api/auth/register \
  -H "Content-Type: application/json" \
  -d '{
    "firstName": "Test",
    "lastName": "User",
    "email": "test@example.com",
    "password": "TestPass123!",
    "phone": "+971501234567",
    "role": "customer",
    "acceptTerms": true
  }'
```

Step 3: Check for Rate Limiting

Look for 429 Too Many Requests errors. If you see this:

```
# Clear rate limit by restarting the server or waiting 15 minutes
```

🔧 Recommended Fixes

Fix #1: Increase Rate Limit for Sign-Up (Temporary)

```
// In backend/src/server.ts - Modify auth limiter
const authLimiter = rateLimit({
  windowMs: 15 * 60 * 1000,
  max: 50, // ☒ Increase from 10 to 50 for development
  skipSuccessfulRequests: false // Let successful requests count
});
```

Fix #2: Add Better Error Feedback

In [frontend/src/pages/auth/RegisterPage.tsx](#) ([frontend/src/pages/auth/RegisterPage.tsx#L195-L205](#)):

```
} catch (error: any) {
  console.error('Registration error:', error);
  const errorMsg = error?.response?.data?.message ||
    error?.message ||
    'Registration failed. Please try again.';
  setErrors({ email: errorMsg });
}
```

Fix #3: Verify Backend Configuration

Create a new file or check [backend/src/config/env.ts](#) ([backend/src/config/env.ts](#)) to ensure:

```
export const frontendUrl = process.env.FRONTEND_URL || 'http://localhost:3000';
export const apiBaseUrl = process.env.BASE_URL || 'http://localhost:5001';
```

📋 Checklist to Resolve

- ☐ Check browser console for actual error message
- ☐ Verify backend is running on `http://localhost:5001`
- ☐ Check if rate limit (429) is being hit - restart server if needed
- ☐ Test with curl to isolate frontend vs backend issue
- ☐ Enable debug logging in both frontend and backend

- [] **Check CORS headers** in response (should include `Access-Control-Allow-Origin`)
 - [] **Verify email service** is configured (sign-up sends verification email)
 - [] **Check MongoDB connection** - user creation requires database
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Quick Fix Steps

1. **Restart the backend server:**

```
cd backend
npm run dev
```

2. **Clear browser cache and localStorage:**

```
// In browser console:
localStorage.clear();
sessionStorage.clear();
location.reload();
```

3. **Reduce rate limit for testing:**

Comment out the auth limiter temporarily in [backend/src/server.ts \(backend/src/server.ts#L137\)](#):

```
// app.use('/api/auth/register', authLimiter); // Temporarily disabled
```

4. **Try signing up again and check the actual error in Dev Tools**
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Additional Notes

- **Email Service:** The sign-up flow sends a verification OTP. Check if email service is properly configured with Hostinger SMTP settings in [backend/.env \(backend/.env#L37-L43\)](#).
- **Phone Validation:** Sign-up requires a phone number in E.164 format. Make sure the phone input includes the country code.
- **Password Requirements:** Password must be 8+ chars with uppercase, lowercase, number, and special character (verified at [frontend/src/pages/auth/RegisterPage.tsx \(frontend/src/pages/auth/RegisterPage.tsx#L77-L79\)](#)).